



Security Watch

E-mail Hoax



The problem

Phishers are stooping to new lows, exploiting would-be humanitarians. Web security firm Sophos said on January 17 that there is a mass e-mail floating around that poses as a plea for aid to help the victims of last month's Tsunami disaster. The e-mail is a vehicle for spreading a virus.

The worm appears with the subject line, "Tsunami donation! Please help!" Recipients are asked to open an attachment titled 'tsunami.exe'. If the attachment is opened, the virus gets forwarded to other users in the address book.

Damages

Sophos said that, so far, it had received only a small number of reports of the worm affecting users.

The e-mail appears to be primarily a vehicle for spreading the virus. It could also initiate a denial-of-service (DoS) attack against a German hacking Web site, in which that site's server would be bombarded with messages and thereby put out of action.

Precautions

It's easy to protect yourself against this one. Just do not open the attachment and delete the mail.

Service Pack 2 (SP2), a major security upgrade for Windows XP released last summer, after a series of crippling attacks.

However, SP2 was never expected to solve all of Microsoft's security problems, according to Stephen Toulouse, a security program manager at the Washington-based company. "We knew we were going to be providing updates for SP2. The goal was always around reducing the number of critical updates," he said.

The third flaw, with a lesser threat rating of 'Important', affects machines running Windows XP and Windows Server 2003. All three, in a variety of ways, could allow an attacker to take control of another computer.

The flaw that affects SP2 takes advantage of a problem with Internet Explorer that could allow an attacker to gain control of a computer if the user were persuaded to visit a malicious Web site.

The other severe flaw could be exploited if a user employs a specially formulated cursor or icon that secretly allows the attacker to gain control of another person's computer.

The new security fixes, released as part of Microsoft's regular monthly security updates, come a week after Microsoft said it would begin offering a free program to remove the most dangerous infections from computers. Many users have already

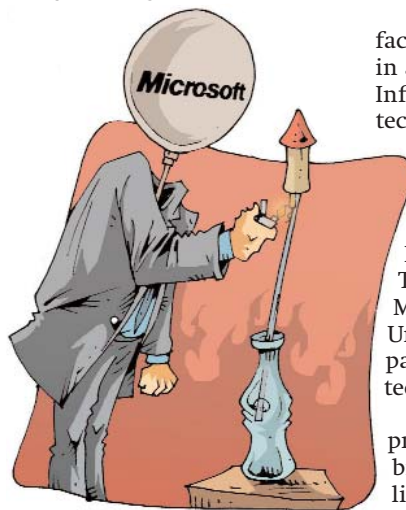
received that removal tool.

Last week, the company also began offering a free program to remove spyware. Spyware can monitor computer users' activities, send annoying pop-up ads and slow computer performance. Microsoft has also confirmed plans to sell its own anti-virus software, which would compete against programs from McAfee, Symantec and others.

MS RESEARCH IN INDIA

Microsoft Research Facility Inaugurated

Microsoft, the global software, services and solutions giant, has launched its research facility in Bangalore.



HOT

Broadband



BSNL's new broadband service offering speeds

between 256 Kbps and 2 Mbps, accessible in 198 cities across India. Plans start as low as Rs 500 and go up to Rs 9,000.

Data Transfer Limits

Under the Home 500 plan, consumers are restricted to 1 GB of data transfer per month. Under other plans, the usage limitation will range from 2 GB to 10 GB.

NOT



Microsoft Research India (MSRI), the third such facility outside the US and only the sixth of its kind in the world, was inaugurated by Minister of State for Science and Technology and Ocean Development, Kapil Sibal.

The state-of-the-art facility will initially focus in areas of Geographic Information Systems (GIS), technologies for emerging markets, multilingual systems and sensor networks. On the occasion, MSRI and the Ministry of Science and Technology signed Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to partner in science and technology projects.

The first collaborative project will be in GIS to bring in a variety of satellite imagery, remote sensing and other geographic



One Silly Question Which software would you like to do away with?



Is Lotus Notes boring or what? Too many complications...never liked it!
Abhishek Jain, Rajasthan



After installing Norton AntiVirus, there were more viruses than before!
Manish Patwardhan, Mumbai



Does anything work perfectly on the Microsoft Windows XP OS?
Sunny Sharma, Mumbai



Ads and spyware! DAP made my PC run at snail's pace!
Sonam Talwar, Gujarat



Tally—the exact opposite of anything that is easy and user-friendly!
Durgesh Dhargalkar, Goa